Of course, it never occurred to me that before many years would pass, Margaret and I would be sitting across from each other as the heads of our respective governments.

• • •

With each passing month of the Carter administration, I became more concerned about the things that were happening—and not happening—in Washington.

Jimmy Carter had run for the presidency on a platform calling for cuts in defense spending and implementation of what the Democrats called “national economic planning.” That meant one thing to me: The Democrats wanted to borrow some of the principles of the Soviets’ failed five-year plans, with Washington setting national production goals, deciding where people worked, what they would do, where they would live, what they would produce.

The Democratic platform also called for “fairer distribution of wealth, income, and power”—code words that to me meant a confiscation of the earnings of people in our country who worked and produced, and their redistribution to people who didn’t.

I’m sure they meant well—liberals usually do—but our economy was one of the great wonders of the world. It didn’t need master planners. It worked because it operated on principles of freedom, millions of people going about their daily business and making free decisions how they wanted to work and live, how they wanted to spend their money, while reaping the rewards of their individual labor.

Our country didn’t need social engineers or economic master planners. Our economic system is based on the law of supply and demand and the right of individuals to choose their line of work, their manner of living, where they live and how they live—all so long as they do not impose on the right of others to enjoy the same freedoms.